Faculty of Social Science
& Public Policy

KING'S CAREERS
& EMPLOYABILITY

THE
POLICY
INSTITUTE

KING'S College LONDON

Engaging with Parliament through its second chamber: the Policy Institute guide

What is policy?



What is policy?

While 'policy' can refer to a wide range of principles and procedures in different settings, in this context, a policy is a set of principles, implemented by government, detailing a plan or a course of action which is backed by law. Policies may be supported by associated legislation that sets out the law that must then be adopted and followed.

'Policymaker' is the term used for people involved in the development or revision of policies. Researchers have a key role in informing and supporting policymakers, and therefore, policy, with research evidence playing an important part in the decisions made by parliamentarians (Owens, 2015; Jasanoff, 2011). While evidence is one input to the policymaking process, there are other influential factors such as experiences, values, traditions and resource availability that also feed into a decision being made. Further information on some of the barriers to the use of evidence is included in section 2.

Why engage with policy as a researcher?

Engaging with the policy landscape can help you to have impact with your research – to create some kind of positive change in the world. If your research can contribute to more effective policy being created, the systematic application of that policy means that a wider population can benefit from your research. This may also benefit your career and your future research. Engaging with policy development can also generate new research questions and drive impact by aligning research with the legislative agenda and societal, economic, and environmental ambitions.

Policy engagement can help universities to fulfil their institutional vision and mission – in the case of King's College London 'to make the world a better place through our excellence in teaching, research and service to society'. Institutions are also assessed on the impact they have on society – through the Research Excellence Framework – which in part then determines the distribution of core public research funding. Policy influence is a key mechanism cited in demonstrating this impact.

Researchers need to be strategic in their approach to policy engagement, dividing their time between writing grants, publishing and building relationships with parliamentarians (Cairney and Oliver, 2020). This resource aims to support you to navigate the challenges of doing this and embed policy engagement and impact in your work.

What is the House of Lords?

The House of Lords is the second chamber (sometimes referred to as the 'Upper House' or 'revising chamber') of the UK Parliament. Alongside the House of Commons, it is responsible for the making and shaping of legislation (around 60% of the time in the chamber) and scrutinising the work of the government (around 40%). In addition to the work done in the Lords Chamber, additional work is done by committees away from the chamber (see section 4) – sometimes referred to as 'off the floor'.

Unlike the House of Commons, which is made up of a democratically elected body of constituency representatives, Members of the House of Lords (who number more than 800, as of summer 2025) come from a range of backgrounds. The vast majority are Life Peers, either political appointees by party leaders or Crossbench Peers who are appointed due to their expertise in, for example, business, public services, culture, academia, law, sport or civil society. There are also a small number of Hereditary Peers, who currently retain the right to sit in the House of Lords, and Lords Spiritual – senior bishops of the Church of England.

How is policy created in the UK?

Government can propose or enact new legislation so that certain policies are underpinned by law. Bills are a piece of primary legislation that must be passed through, scrutinised and approved by Parliament before they become legislation and, therefore, law. Once a Bill is approved, it becomes an Act of Parliament and part of law. Laws can enforce policies. Parliament consists of the House of Commons, the House of Lords and the Monarch (whose Royal Assent converts Bills to Acts).

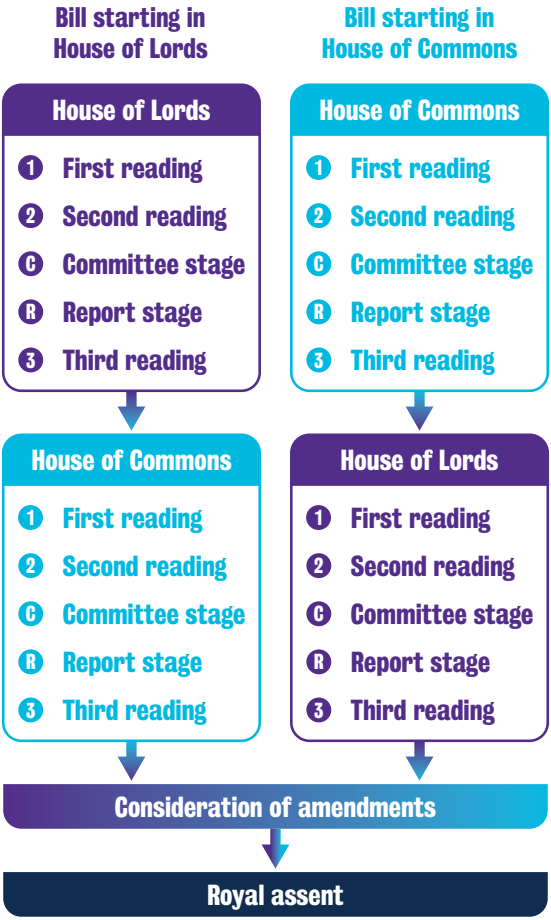
The legislative process

Draft legislation, known as a Bill, can be introduced in either House and proceeds through a series of stages as indicated below. The Bill must be approved in the same form in both Houses to become an Act (ie become law). For more information on what happens at each stage, see the UK Parliament website.

Tools and resources

- **Gov.uk** How government works
- **Parliament.uk** How Parliament works
- **Parliament.uk** The policy development process
- **Parliament.uk** Explanation of general elections
- **The Institute for Government** Series of explainers

Figure 1 Passage of a Bill



References

Kenny, C., Rose, D.C., Hobbs, A., Tyler, C. & Blackstock, J. (2017) The Role of Research in the UK Parliament Volume One. London, UK, Houses of Parliament.

Owens, S. 2015. Knowledge, Policy, and Expertise, Oxford University Press, Oxford, UK